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Professor Hanna Bäck and the selection committee
Department of Political Science, Lund University

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Re: PhD student in Political Science, "A Divisive Spiral?" (PA2026/2879)

Dear Professor Bäck, dear members of the committee,

If a politician sounds more hostile on Facebook than in the Riksdag, either the politician has changed their tone or the model reading them has. Your project asks whether politicians, voters and algorithms drive each other into a spiral of affective polarisation. My research so far has been about the second half of that sentence: whether a machine-labelled measure of opinion means the same thing on different platforms. I am applying because I want to answer both, and because your project is where social media research and the political science I want to learn meet.

Who I am. I hold an MSc in Data Analytics from the University of Portsmouth (Distinction, 2025), which I studied as a Chevening Scholar. For eight years I have collected and analysed online text, first as a computer science student in Pakistan taking data projects on Fiverr, then as a data engineer for companies in nine countries. Today I work at M+C Saatchi Fluency in London, which analyses social media for global brands and UK government, and I am co-founder and CTO of Artemis AI, a social media intelligence start-up where I lead a team of five.

Research related to the project's themes. My MSc thesis asked how the public reacted to UK economic policy across 255,446 comments from X, Reddit, YouTube and Quora: taxation, welfare, inflation and stimulus, the stuff of everyday partisan argument. Its weakness taught me most. The classifier was checked against labels seeded by a lexicon, and I had assumed that a "negative" post means the same on Reddit as on YouTube. With my supervisor, Dr Ella Haig, I turned that into a methods paper, *Is the Platform Part of the Measurement?* (arXiv:2610.16757), which treats each platform as a survey mode. In the simulation I built, pooling platforms at face value gives the wrong sign of aggregate sentiment on nearly a quarter of days. At Fluency I was an analyst on a twelve-month study of 100,845 Brandwatch and 170,542 Reddit mentions, and my work there feeds reports read by government communications teams.

Automated text analysis. I have fine-tuned BERT, XLM-R, DistilBERT and DeBERTa classifiers and built LLM labelling at scale. At Artemis AI, Claude labels about 6,000 posts and explains each label, rules mined from those explanations become the prompt for DeepSeek, and its labels train our own classifiers, all checked against posts our team labelled by hand. Much of that work is about hostility: toxicity classifiers, a detector for sudden storms of hostile comments, and filters that stop dialect and banter being read as toxicity. That last problem is close to yours: telling real animosity from heated but ordinary political talk.

Programming and large-scale social science data. I work in Python and SQL every day. At Dubizzle Labs I led three engineers running more than 500 collectors across 15 markets in English, Arabic, Urdu and Hindi; at Fluency I collect from ten platforms daily through licensed feeds and our own collectors, with an AI agent I designed that repairs broken collectors. I also write web-scraping-guide.com, a free public guide to web data collection that covers its legal and ethical limits.

Languages. I do not speak Swedish or Finnish, and I would be honest that this is a gap for a project on Swedish and Finnish material. I have, though, spent years building and checking text models in languages I do not read fluently, which is exactly why my research plan relies on native-speaker gold samples rather than trust in the model. I would begin Swedish courses in my first term.

Working independently and with others. I have finished a dissertation, a paper and a start-up build alongside a demanding job, and I am used to fixed deadlines that do not move. I lead a cross-functional team, and much of my work is explaining technical results to people who are not technical.

Why Lund, and why now. Industry taught me to measure what people say online at scale. It did not teach me to explain political behaviour, and that is the training I want. Your department's strength in democracy research and political psychology, and the project's collaboration with Professor Emma Renström, would give me the theory my work lacks. Your finding that a factual message with a party cue raises affective polarisation among Swedish voters (Bäck et al. 2023) is the voter side of the spiral; my plan studies the elite side, whether engagement teaches

politicians to be more polarising, and it starts by making sure the measure is equal to the comparison. I have not run an experiment and have no formal training in political science, and I would close both gaps through the doctoral courses and the project's experiments.

Eligibility. My MSc comprises 90 second-cycle ECTS credits (180 UK credits), including an independently written thesis of 30 ECTS (60 UK credits), examined and graded at 78/100. It studies public opinion on government economic policy with automated text analysis, and I would ask the department to assess it as equivalent in relation to the project. My BS in Computer Science (FAST-NUCES, Pakistan) gives a further 130 credit hours. The thesis, transcripts and the arXiv paper are attached.

My references are Dr Ella Haig, Associate Professor in AI, University of Portsmouth, my thesis supervisor and co-author (Ella.Haig@port.ac.uk), and Dr Fahad Ahmad, Senior Lecturer, University of Portsmouth, who taught and assessed me (Fahad.Ahmad@port.ac.uk). I can start on 1 January 2027 and would move to Lund. Thank you for considering my application.

Yours sincerely,
Asad Ikram